

David Hume's Science of Human Nature

Empiricism, Causation, and the Sentiments – the Shape of a Skeptical Naturalism

Lasha Chochua

Table of contents

1	Introduction: The Science of Man	2
2	The Empiricist Foundation: Impressions, Ideas, and the Copy Principle	3
3	Hume's Fork: Two Kinds of Knowledge	5
4	Causation	6
4.1	The search for the impression of necessary connection	6
4.2	The relocation of necessity into the mind	7
4.3	What Hume did and did not deny	7
5	Induction: The Problem of the Foundation of Experience	8
6	Skepticism, the Self, and the External World	9
6.1	The bundle theory of the self	10
6.2	The external world	10
6.3	Mitigated skepticism	10
7	Moral Philosophy	11
7.1	Reason is not the source of morality	11
7.2	Morality is founded on sentiment	12
7.3	Sympathy and the general point of view	13
7.4	Utility, and the virtues	13
7.5	Justice as an artificial virtue	14
8	The Passions and Human Freedom	15
9	Religion	15

10 The Reception and Afterlife of Hume	17
11 Modern Criticism of Hume	18
11.1 The narrowness of Humean reason	18
11.2 The theory of ideas and the Copy Principle	19
11.3 Causation and the laws of nature	19
11.4 The self	20
11.5 Moral philosophy: motivation, the is–ought gap, and normativity	20
11.6 Religion: the argument against miracles	21
11.7 What survives	21
12 Conclusion: The Shape of Hume’s Thought	22
13 Suggested Primary Reading	22

1 Introduction: The Science of Man

David Hume (1711–1776) is, on most reckonings, the most important philosopher to have written in English, and the figure in whom British empiricism reaches both its sharpest formulation and its most unsettling conclusions. His ambition was announced in the subtitle of his first and greatest work, *A Treatise of Human Nature* (1739–1740): to introduce “the experimental method of reasoning into moral subjects” – to do for the mind what Newton had done for the heavens, founding a *science of man* on careful observation of how the understanding, the passions, and the moral sentiments actually operate. The *Treatise*, in Hume’s famous lament, “fell dead-born from the press,” and he later recast its central doctrines in two more accessible works that he preferred: the *Enquiry concerning Human Understanding* (1748), which contains his mature treatment of causation, induction, and miracles, and the *Enquiry concerning the Principles of Morals* (1751), which he judged “incomparably the best” of all his writings.

The unity of Hume’s philosophy lies in a single method applied without flinching across every domain, and in the characteristic result it produces. The method is empiricist: every idea must be traced to the impression, whether of sensation or reflection, from which it is copied, and any term that cannot be so traced is to be treated as empty. Applied as a critical instrument, this principle dissolves a series of notions that philosophy had taken for granted – the necessary connection between cause and effect, the rational foundation of inductive inference, the simple and continuing self, the objectivity of moral and aesthetic distinctions. In each case the empiricist test reveals that *reason* cannot supply what we had assumed it supplied. But Hume is not, in the end, a merely negative skeptic. Where the analysis exposes a gap that reason cannot fill, he shows that the gap

is filled all the same – by *custom*, by *sentiment*, by natural propensities of the imagination that operate beneath and beyond reason. This is the posture for which his philosophy is best characterised: a *skeptical naturalism*, skeptical about the pretensions of reason and naturalist about the springs that actually move us.

The empiricist test and the naturalist remainder: trace the idea to its impression; where reason falls short, nature supplies the rest

The recurring move. Hume takes a concept we rely on – causation, the inference from past to future, the self, moral good and evil – and applies the empiricist test: from what impression is this idea derived? In each case the test shows that the concept, as we ordinarily understand it, outruns anything reason or the senses can warrant; the supposed rational foundation is missing. Hume does not then conclude that we should stop using the concept, for nature does not permit it. He concludes instead that its real source lies not in reason but in a natural disposition – habit after repeated experience, the felt determination of the mind, the propensities of the imagination, the sentiments of approbation and blame. Reason is dethroned; nature takes its place; and belief and conduct go on as before, now correctly understood.

The chapters that follow set out the empiricist foundation, then the three questions the request singles out – the theory of knowledge, the analysis of causation, and the moral philosophy – and then the further domains in which the same method does its work: the self and skepticism, the passions and human freedom, and religion. A final pair of sections traces the reception of these ideas, which have shaped the agenda of philosophy from Kant to the present day.

2 The Empiricist Foundation: Impressions, Ideas, and the Copy Principle

Hume's epistemology begins with a deceptively simple inventory of the mind's contents, which he calls *perceptions* and divides into two classes by their force and vivacity. *Impressions* are the lively, forceful perceptions: our sensations as we feel them, and our passions and emotions as we undergo them – the heat felt now, the present pang of anger. *Ideas* are the fainter copies of impressions that occur in thinking, remembering, and imagining – the recollection of the heat, the thought of anger when we are calm. The difference is one of degree of liveliness, not of kind: an idea is, so to speak, a faded impression. This distinction looks modest, but it carries the weight of the entire system, for on it Hume erects his fundamental principle.

The Copy Principle

Every simple idea is derived from, and is an exact copy of, a corresponding simple impression. Complex ideas may be assembled by the imagination from simpler ones, so that we can form the idea of a golden mountain we have never seen by joining the ideas of gold and of a mountain; but each *simple* constituent must ultimately trace back to a simple impression actually had in sensation or feeling. In general, there is no simple idea without a prior corresponding impression. This yields Hume's decisive critical test: whenever a philosophical term is suspected of being empty, ask from what impression its idea is derived. If no such impression can be produced, the term is without genuine meaning – a piece of "sophistry and illusion."

The Copy Principle is at once a theory of the origin of ideas and a weapon. As a weapon, it is the razor Hume turns on the inflated vocabulary of traditional metaphysics: substance, necessary connection, the self as a simple substance, the *vis* or active power in bodies. In each case he will demand the originating impression, and in each case, finding none of the kind required, he will conclude that the idea must be either spurious or quite other than philosophers had supposed. The closing words of the first *Enquiry* give the doctrine its most celebrated and most polemical expression: any volume that contains neither abstract reasoning about quantity and number nor experimental reasoning about matter of fact contains nothing but sophistry and illusion, and should be committed to the flames.

Hume is honest enough to record the one apparent counterexample to his own principle, the case of the *missing shade of blue*. Suppose a person familiar with all the shades of blue but one, arranged before them in gradation with a single gap; presented with the series, they could, Hume concedes, form for themselves the idea of the missing shade though they had never had the corresponding impression. The example shows that a simple idea may, in this one peculiar circumstance, arise without its impression. Hume notes the exception and – characteristically for a thinker more interested in the general workings of the mind than in airtight systems – judges it too singular to require him to alter his general principle. The candour is itself instructive about his method, which is empirical and approximate rather than deductive and rigid.

To the inventory of perceptions Hume adds an account of how ideas hang together: the *association of ideas*, a kind of gentle force of attraction in the mental world, analogous to gravitation in the physical. Ideas are associated, and the mind led naturally from one to another, by three relations: *resemblance*, *contiguity* in time and place, and *cause and effect*. This last is the most important of the three and the most far-reaching, for it is the principle that carries thought beyond what is immediately present to the senses and memory – and it is therefore the hinge on which the analysis of causation and inductive

inference will turn.

The empiricist test and the naturalist remainder: trace the idea to its impression; where reason falls short, nature supplies the rest

Concept tested: the whole stock of our ideas, including the abstract notions of metaphysics. *Test:* every simple idea must copy a prior simple impression. *Remainder:* ideas that pass the test are legitimate; those that do not – substance, power, necessary connection as ordinarily conceived – are exposed as empty or as something other than supposed, and the mind’s movement among ideas is governed not by logic but by the natural associative relations of resemblance, contiguity, and causation.

3 Hume’s Fork: Two Kinds of Knowledge

Before the analysis of causation can proceed, Hume draws the distinction that organises his whole theory of knowledge, the division of all the objects of human reason into two exhaustive and mutually exclusive kinds, now universally known as *Hume’s Fork*.

Relations of ideas and matters of fact

Relations of ideas are the propositions of mathematics and logic – geometry, algebra, arithmetic, and whatever is intuitively or demonstratively certain. They are knowable *a priori*, by the operation of thought alone, independently of anything existing in the world; their distinguishing mark is that their denial implies a contradiction. “Three times five equals fifteen” expresses a relation among ideas, and to deny it is to contradict oneself. *Matters of fact*, by contrast, concern what actually exists and what actually happens. They are not certified by reason alone, for the contrary of any matter of fact remains always possible and implies no contradiction: that the sun will rise tomorrow is no more demonstrable than that it will not, since “the sun will not rise tomorrow” is perfectly conceivable and self-consistent. Matters of fact are known only through experience – and, where they reach beyond what is immediately observed, only through the relation of cause and effect.

The Fork is double-edged. On the one side it secures the certainty of mathematics, at the price of emptying it of factual content: the demonstrative sciences tell us about the relations of our own ideas, not about the world. On the other side it consigns all knowledge of the world to experience, and thereby strips it of demonstrative certainty: no matter of fact can be proved by reasoning alone. Everything Hume says about causation and induction follows from locating causal claims firmly on the second prong. Because a cause and its effect are distinct events, and because the existence of one can always be conceived without the existence of the other without contradiction, the connection

between them can never be a relation of ideas established by reason; it can only be something learned from, and grounded in, experience. The question then becomes what, exactly, experience teaches and on what its further inferences rest – and that question opens onto Hume’s two most famous arguments.

4 Causation

Causation is the centre of Hume’s theoretical philosophy, because it is the relation that carries us beyond the evidence of the senses and memory to everything we believe about the unobserved. All reasoning concerning matters of fact, Hume argues, is founded on the relation of cause and effect: it is only by inferring causes from effects, and effects from causes, that we believe in anything we do not presently perceive. So the analysis of causation is the analysis of the very engine of factual belief.

4.1 The search for the impression of necessary connection

Hume’s procedure is the empiricist test applied to the idea of causation, and in particular to the element in it that does the real work: the idea of *necessary connection*, the supposed tie or bond by which a cause produces its effect and makes it inevitable. We believe not merely that the effect follows the cause but that it *must* follow, that there is a power in the cause that brings the effect about. From what impression is this idea of necessary connection, of power, of the “must,” derived?

Hume examines the candidates and finds them wanting. Consider a single instance of causation as carefully as we like – one billiard ball striking another. By the senses we observe three things, and only three. We observe *contiguity*: the two events are adjacent in space and time. We observe *temporal priority and succession*: the motion of the first ball precedes the motion of the second. And we observe, when we attend to many such instances, *constant conjunction*: events of the first kind are regularly followed by events of the second. But however closely we scrutinise a single case, we never observe a *necessary connection*. We see the first ball move and then the second move; we never see any power, force, or tie passing between them that compels the second to move. Nor does turning inward help, to the experience of our own willing: when I will my arm to rise and it rises, I am conscious of the volition and then of the motion, but the actual power by which the will moves the body is as hidden from me as the power in the billiard ball. The impression of necessary connection is nowhere to be found in the objects, in any single instance, or in the operations of the mind upon the body.

4.2 The relocation of necessity into the mind

If the idea of necessary connection has a source at all – and we plainly do possess it – it must arise from something other than the observation of single instances, for these never contain it. Hume’s solution is the masterstroke of the analysis. What is added when we pass from a single instance to many is nothing in the objects, which are exactly alike in each case; it is something in *us*. After we have observed events of one kind constantly conjoined with events of another, the mind acquires a *habit* or *custom*: upon the appearance of the one, it is *determined* to pass, by a natural and felt transition, to the idea of the other. The repetition produces no new quality in the objects, but it produces a new disposition in the observer – a propensity to expect the effect on the appearance of the cause. And it is *this felt determination of the mind*, this internal impression of being carried from cause to effect, that is the impression from which the idea of necessary connection is at last copied. Necessity, Hume concludes in his most quoted formula on the subject, is something that exists in the mind, not in objects; it is a feature of the way we think about events, projected by the imagination onto the events themselves.

The two definitions of cause

Hume offers two definitions, corresponding to the two aspects his analysis has separated. By the first, a cause is an object followed by another, where all objects similar to the first are followed by objects similar to the second – the *constant-conjunction* or regularity definition, which captures what is there in the world. By the second, a cause is an object followed by another, whose appearance always conveys the thought to that other – the *mental-determination* definition, which captures the habit-induced transition in the mind that is the source of the idea of necessity. The two are not rival accounts of one thing but the two halves of Hume’s analysis: the objective regularity that experience supplies, and the subjective propensity that experience builds in us and that we then read back into the regularity as a “must.”

4.3 What Hume did and did not deny

It is essential, and contested, to state the upshot precisely. On the traditional reading – often called the reductionist or projectivist interpretation – Hume reduces causation in the objects to regularity plus the mind’s projected expectation: there is, in mind-independent reality, nothing more to one event’s causing another than the one’s being regularly followed by the other, and the felt “necessity” is a psychological addition with no counterpart in things. A vigorous minority reading, the so-called *New Hume* or skeptical-realist interpretation, holds that Hume does not deny that there are real powers or “secret connexions” in nature; he denies only that we can ever *observe*, *conceive*, or *know* them, our idea of necessary connection being confined to the projected feeling, while the real

causal powers remain hidden behind the veil of experience. The texts give some support to each, and the dispute is among the liveliest in Hume scholarship. What is not in dispute is the negative core: whatever the ultimate metaphysics, Hume holds that the *idea* of causal necessity we actually possess is derived not from any insight into the objects but from custom-bred expectation, and that no reasoning could ever exhibit the connection between a cause and its effect as a relation of ideas.

The empiricist test and the naturalist remainder: trace the idea to its impression; where reason falls short, nature supplies the rest

Concept tested: the necessary connection between cause and effect. *Test:* from what impression is the idea of necessity derived? No single instance, in objects or in the will, presents any such impression – only contiguity, succession, and, across many cases, constant conjunction. *Remainder:* the idea of necessity is copied not from the objects but from the felt determination of the mind, the habit of expecting the effect after repeated conjunction – necessity lies in the mind and is projected onto the world.

5 Induction: The Problem of the Foundation of Experience

The analysis of causation contains within it Hume's most influential single argument, the skeptical argument concerning inductive inference – what later philosophy simply calls *the problem of induction*. It is the argument the Russell notes track to its modern descendants, and it is arguably the most durable of all Hume's contributions.

The argument proceeds in steps. All reasoning about matters of fact beyond present experience rests on the relation of cause and effect. All such causal inference rests, in turn, on a single assumption: that the unobserved resembles the observed – that the future will be like the past, that instances of which we have had no experience must resemble those of which we have had experience. Hume calls this the supposition that the course of nature continues uniformly the same, the *uniformity of nature*. The whole of our expectation that bread will nourish us tomorrow as it did yesterday, that fire will burn and water drown, depends on it. The question on which everything turns is then: what justifies this assumption?

Hume shows, by elimination, that nothing does – nothing, at least, that counts as *reasoning*. The uniformity principle cannot be established by *demonstrative* reasoning, by relations of ideas, for there is no contradiction in supposing the course of nature to change: a world in which bread suddenly ceased to nourish is perfectly conceivable, and what is

conceivable cannot be ruled out by logic. Nor can the principle be established by *probable* or *experiential* reasoning – by appeal to the fact that nature has been uniform in the past – for any such argument is circular. To argue “nature has been uniform in the past, therefore it will be uniform in the future” is already to assume that the future resembles the past, which is the very principle in question. Every experiential argument for the uniformity of nature presupposes the uniformity of nature. The principle on which all our factual reasoning rests can therefore be founded neither on demonstration nor, without vicious circularity, on experience. Inductive inference has no rational foundation.

This is a genuinely radical result, and Hume does not soften it: the conclusions we draw from experience are “not founded on reasoning, or any process of the understanding.” Yet – and here the naturalist completes the skeptic – we go on drawing them, inevitably and usefully, for we cannot do otherwise. What carries us from the observed to the unobserved is not an argument but a principle of human nature: *custom* or *habit*. Having found that fire has always warmed us, we are determined by habit to expect that it will warm us again, and the expectation is irresistible whether or not it can be justified. Custom, Hume writes, is the great guide of human life; it is what renders our experience useful and makes us expect a future course of events resembling the past. The vindication of induction is thus not rational but natural: it is not that we *ought*, by some demonstrable warrant, to reason inductively, but that we are so constituted that we cannot help it, and that nature has wisely entrusted so necessary an operation to instinct rather than to the slow and fallible deductions of reason.

The empiricist test and the naturalist remainder: trace the idea to its impression; where reason falls short, nature supplies the rest

Concept tested: the inference from observed to unobserved, and its assumption that the future will resemble the past. *Test:* can the uniformity of nature be justified by reason? Not by demonstration, for its denial is conceivable; not by experience, for that argument is circular. *Remainder:* inductive inference rests on no reasoning at all, but on custom – the habit, bred by repetition, of expecting the like to follow the like – which nature has made the great guide of human life.

6 Skepticism, the Self, and the External World

The same method, turned on the objects we are most certain of, yields Hume’s treatment of personal identity and of the external world, and his considered position on skepticism itself.

6.1 The bundle theory of the self

Few of Hume's arguments are more startling than his denial that we have any idea of a simple, continuing self. Philosophers, he observes, suppose that we are at every moment intimately conscious of a self – a single, identical, persisting subject that owns our perceptions and endures through them. Hume applies the Copy Principle: from what impression could the idea of such a self be derived? An impression would have to be constant and invariable through the whole course of our lives, since the self is supposed to be so; but no impression is constant and invariable. When he enters most intimately into what he calls himself, Hume reports, he always stumbles on some particular perception – of heat or cold, light or shade, love or hatred – and never catches *himself* without a perception, never observes anything but the perceptions. The self, he concludes, is nothing but *a bundle or collection of different perceptions*, in perpetual flux and movement, succeeding one another with inconceivable rapidity. There is no underlying theatre in which the perceptions appear; there are only the perceptions. The belief in a single continuing self is a fiction that the imagination constructs, misled by the smooth resemblance and causal connection among our perceptions into ascribing to them an identity they do not possess. Notably, in the Appendix to the *Treatise* Hume confessed himself unable to render his own account fully consistent, admitting that on reflection he found himself involved in a labyrinth from which he could see no escape – one of the most disarming admissions of difficulty in the history of philosophy.

6.2 The external world

A parallel analysis governs our belief in body – in the continued and distinct existence of external objects when unperceived. Neither the senses nor reason, Hume argues, can justify this belief. The senses present only present perceptions and cannot testify to the existence of anything beyond or behind them; reason cannot demonstrate that perceptions are caused by, or resemble, external objects. The belief is produced, once again, by the imagination, working on certain features of our perceptions – their *constancy* (the same objects recur unchanged after interruptions) and their *coherence* (their changes exhibit regular patterns) – which together prompt us to feign a continued existence that would smooth over the gaps. The belief in the external world is natural, universal, and irresistible, but it is the offspring of imaginative propensity rather than of evidence.

6.3 Mitigated skepticism

These results raise the question of how to live with such conclusions, and Hume's answer defines his temper. He distinguishes *excessive* or Pyrrhonian skepticism, which would have us suspend all belief, from the *mitigated* or Academic skepticism he endorses. The

excessive skeptic refutes himself in practice, for nature does not permit suspension of belief: the moment one leaves the study, the doubts of the closet vanish, and one eats, converses, and reasons inductively like everyone else. Nature, Hume writes, is always too strong for principle, and no one was ever able to maintain total skepticism for an hour. The lesson is not despair but modesty. Mitigated skepticism takes from its excessive cousin a lasting sense of the narrow limits of human understanding and a corresponding distrust of dogmatism and system-building, while accepting, with good humour, the beliefs that nature forces upon us. Philosophy cannot found our everyday convictions, but it can chasten our pretensions; the proper conclusion is to confine our inquiries to subjects suited to the slender capacities of the human mind, and to hold even our best conclusions with a becoming diffidence.

The empiricist test and the naturalist remainder: trace the idea to its impression; where reason falls short, nature supplies the rest

Concepts tested: the simple continuing self and the external world existing unperceived. *Test:* from what impression is each derived, and can reason justify it? No constant impression yields a continuing self; neither sense nor reason warrants belief in unperceived body. *Remainder:* both are fictions of the imagination – the self a bundle of perceptions unified by resemblance and causation, the external world a continued existence feigned to smooth the gaps in perception – beliefs that nature compels and that mitigated skepticism accepts while abandoning all dogmatic pretension.

7 Moral Philosophy

Hume's moral philosophy is, by his own estimate, the crown of his work, and it applies the now-familiar pattern to the domain of value: reason is shown to be incapable of grounding morality, and the office it cannot perform is assigned to *sentiment*. The argument has several distinct strands, which together constitute one of the founding statements of the sentimentalist tradition in ethics.

7.1 Reason is not the source of morality

Hume's first and most provocative thesis is that moral distinctions are not derived from reason. His argument is motivational. Morality, he observes, is *practical*: moral judgments influence our passions and actions, move us to do some things and to forbear others. But reason alone, he contends, is inert – it discovers relations of ideas and matters of fact, but the bare apprehension of a truth never of itself moves us to act; only a passion, a desire or aversion, can do that. Reason can inform a passion of its object or its means, but

cannot originate action on its own. From this Hume draws his most notorious epigram: reason is, and ought only to be, the slave of the passions, and can pretend to no office but to serve and obey them. If reason alone cannot move us and morality does move us, then morality cannot be the offspring of reason alone. Vice and virtue are not relations that the understanding discovers, nor matters of fact that it ascertains; if they were, they would leave us cold.

The is–ought observation

At the close of his discussion Hume adds a remark that has had an afterlife out of all proportion to its few sentences. He notices that the authors of moral systems proceed for a while with ordinary reasonings, establishing what *is* and *is not* the case, and then imperceptibly slip into propositions about what *ought* and *ought not* to be – a change of copula that seems to pass unremarked yet is, he says, of the last consequence, since the new relation of "ought" needs to be explained, and it seems inconceivable how it could be deduced from premises entirely different from it. The passage is the origin of what later philosophy calls the is–ought gap or Hume's Law: the thesis that no purely normative conclusion can be validly derived from purely factual premises. Whether Hume meant to assert an unbridgeable logical gap, or only to demand that the transition be explained, is debated; but the passage has become the charter of the claim that facts alone cannot entail values.

7.2 Morality is founded on sentiment

If not from reason, whence do moral distinctions arise? From a *moral sentiment* – a distinctive feeling of approbation or disapprobation that certain qualities and characters arouse in us when we contemplate them. Here Hume deploys an analogy with the secondary qualities, colours and sounds, which modern philosophy had already removed from the objects and located in the perceiving mind. Virtue and vice, he argues, are like colours: they are not qualities discoverable in actions by reason, but perceptions in the mind of the observer. His most vivid illustration is the case of wilful murder. Examine the act in every light, search it as closely as you please for the matter of fact called vice; you will never find it in the action itself – in the objective relations and events. The viciousness escapes you entirely until you turn your reflection inward, into your own breast, and find there a sentiment of disapprobation that the contemplation of the act arouses. The vice, then, lies not in the act but in the feeling; morality is, Hume writes, more properly felt than judged of. Moral qualities are not discovered by reason in the act itself; they arise through the sentiment with which a properly situated observer responds to it. On this projectivist reading – to which Hume's own image of the mind gilding and staining objects with colours borrowed from internal sentiment lends support – moral facts are,

in effect, projected onto the world rather than found in it; though how far Hume meant to commit himself to such a metaphysics, rather than only to deny that reason discovers vice, is itself debated.

7.3 Sympathy and the general point of view

A sentiment-based morality must explain how our moral judgements come to be *shared* and *stable* rather than merely idiosyncratic, and Hume's mechanism for this is *sympathy*. By sympathy he means the communication of sentiments from one person to another – a propensity by which the observed feelings and fortunes of others are converted into corresponding feelings in ourselves, so that we are pleased by what pleases them and pained by what pains them. Sympathy is what allows the happiness and misery that a person's character produces in others to register as approbation or blame in us, and it explains why we approve qualities useful and agreeable not only to ourselves but to those around the person judged.

But sympathy is partial and variable: it is stronger for those near us, weaker for the distant, and would yield judgements that shifted with our position and varied from person to person. To convert these fluctuating sentiments into the steady, public language of morals, Hume holds that we correct them by adopting a *general* or *common point of view* – a settled standpoint from which we consider a character's effects on the person himself and on his usual circle, abstracting from our own particular interest and situation. From this common point of view the judgements of different observers can converge, and the language of moral praise and blame acquires the shared, impersonal character it actually has. The corrective standpoint plays, in Hume's ethics, a role analogous to that of the impartial spectator in his friend Adam Smith's, though Hume builds it out of the correction of sympathy rather than out of an internalised observer.

7.4 Utility, and the virtues

What qualities, then, do we approve from the general point of view? Hume's survey yields a fourfold classification: we approve qualities *useful to others* (such as benevolence and justice), qualities *useful to their possessor* (such as prudence and industry), qualities *immediately agreeable to others* (such as wit and good manners), and qualities *immediately agreeable to their possessor* (such as cheerfulness and tranquillity). Utility – the tendency of a quality to promote the good of those affected by it – emerges as a principal source of moral approbation, and Hume's emphasis on it makes him a major forerunner of utilitarianism, though he is not a utilitarian in the later, calculating sense: approbation for him is a felt response to perceived usefulness and agreeableness, not the output of a maximising computation.

7.5 Justice as an artificial virtue

The deepest and most influential part of Hume's ethics is his account of *justice* as an *artificial* virtue, which must be distinguished from the *natural* virtues. Natural virtues, such as benevolence or compassion, please us immediately and operate without any human contrivance. Justice – by which Hume means above all respect for property and the keeping of promises – is different. Its individual acts are often not immediately beneficial and may even be harmful in the particular case (returning a fortune to a miser or a bigot does no good to anyone), and our approval of justice cannot be explained by any natural instinct directed at each just act. Justice is approved, rather, because the *general scheme* or system of rules is indispensable to society. It is an *artifice*: a set of conventions that human beings gradually establish, not by explicit contract but by a slowly growing sense of common interest, to remedy a specific predicament. That predicament is the conjunction of two facts – the relative *scarcity* of external goods and the *limited generosity* of human beings, whose benevolence is real but confined largely to themselves and their intimates. In conditions of moderate scarcity and limited generosity, stable rules assigning possessions and enforcing promises are necessary for any extensive cooperation, and so the convention of justice arises and, once established, is approved both for its evident utility and, through sympathy with the public interest, as a virtue. The rules are general and must be inflexibly observed, since the benefit lies in the system's stability rather than in the utility of each separate application. This account – justice as a conventional, rule-governed institution that emerges unplanned from the pursuit of common interest, like language or money – is one of Hume's most fertile ideas, a forerunner of later theories of convention and spontaneous order and a clear point of contact with Smith's analysis of justice as the enforceable pillar of society.

The empiricist test and the naturalist remainder: trace the idea to its impression; where reason falls short, nature supplies the rest

Concept tested: moral good and evil as objective qualities discoverable by reason. *Test:* reason alone is inert and cannot motivate, and inspection of a vicious act reveals no matter of fact called "vice" in the act itself. *Remainder:* morality is founded on a sentiment of approbation or disapprobation, communicated and extended by sympathy and stabilised by a general point of view; utility is a chief ground of approval; and justice is an artificial virtue, a convention arising from scarcity and limited generosity and approved for its indispensable social utility.

8 The Passions and Human Freedom

Between the theory of the understanding and the moral philosophy stands Hume's theory of the passions, the subject of the second Book of the *Treatise*, which supplies the motivational psychology the ethics requires. Hume distinguishes *direct* passions, which arise immediately from pleasure and pain or the prospect of them (desire and aversion, hope and fear, joy and grief), from *indirect* passions, which arise through a more complex route. The indirect passions – chiefly pride and humility, love and hatred – are produced, on Hume's ingenious account, by a *double association* of impressions and ideas: pride, for instance, arises when something related to me (its idea associated with the idea of self) and independently pleasant (its impression associated with the pleasant impression of pride) combines the two associations, so that a fine house that is mine produces, by this double relation, the agreeable passion of pride. The mechanism is a further application of the associationist psychology that governs the understanding, now extended to the affective life.

From this psychology follows Hume's treatment of the will and of human freedom, his *reconciling project* concerning liberty and necessity – one of the foundational statements of *compatibilism*. The longstanding dispute about free will, Hume argues, is merely verbal, dissolved once the terms are clarified. *Necessity*, properly understood, is nothing but the constant conjunction of similar objects and the inference of the mind from one to the other – exactly the analysis given for causation; and human actions, Hume observes, are in fact as regularly conjoined with motives, characters, and circumstances as any natural events, so that we infer people's conduct from their characters as confidently as we infer natural effects from their causes. Necessity in this sense plainly does apply to human action. *Liberty*, meanwhile, when it means anything real, does not mean freedom from causal determination – a will uncaused would be mere chance, and chance is no foundation for responsibility – but the power of acting *according to the determinations of the will*: the absence of external constraint, the capacity to act as one chooses. Liberty so understood is not only compatible with necessity but requires it, for moral responsibility presupposes that actions flow from the agent's durable character; were actions not caused by character, there would be no ground for praising or blaming the person for them. Liberty and necessity, far from conflicting, are both indispensable to morality. The argument is a direct ancestor of many modern compatibilist positions.

9 Religion

No account of Hume is complete without his philosophy of religion, the domain in which his skeptical method was most subversive and, in his own century, most scandalous – so much so that he withheld his most radical work from publication during his lifetime.

Three contributions stand out.

In the essay “Of Miracles,” in the first *Enquiry*, Hume applies the principle that a wise person proportions belief to evidence. A miracle is, by definition, a violation of a law of nature, and a law of nature is established by a firm and unalterable experience – the uniform testimony of all observation. The evidence against any miracle is therefore as complete as evidence from experience can be. Against this stands the testimony of witnesses who report the miracle. Hume’s principle for weighing the two is exact: no testimony is sufficient to establish a miracle unless the falsehood of that testimony would be more miraculous – more contrary to experience – than the event it reports. Since human testimony is frequently mistaken or mendacious, while the laws of nature are supported by uniform experience, this condition is, Hume argues, essentially never met; and he adds a battery of further considerations about the unreliability of witnesses, the human appetite for wonder, and the tendency of miracle reports to flourish among the ignorant. The argument does not assert that miracles are impossible, or even that no conceivable testimony could in principle suffice, but that testimony has not, in practice, met the standard required to make belief in one reasonable.

In the *Natural History of Religion*, Hume turns from the rational credentials of religion to its psychological and historical *causes*, treating religious belief as a natural phenomenon to be explained rather than a truth to be assessed. Religion arises, he argues, not from disinterested contemplation of the order of nature but from the hopes and fears of ordinary life – from anxiety about the unknown causes of fortune and misfortune – and its historical course runs from an original polytheism, the projection of human-like agencies behind the diverse powers of nature, toward monotheism, rather than the reverse.

His masterpiece in this domain is the *Dialogues concerning Natural Religion*, published posthumously in 1779 and constructed so that no single character simply speaks for Hume. Its principal target is the *argument from design* – the inference from the apparent contrivance and adaptation of the world to an intelligent designer. Through the sceptical voice of Philo, Hume presses a series of objections that have shaped every subsequent discussion: the analogy between the world and a humanly designed machine is weak, and analogical inference is only as strong as the likeness it rests on; even if the inference held, it could not establish the *infinite, unique, or morally perfect* deity of religion, but at most a finite, perhaps plural, perhaps imperfect designer proportioned to a finite and flawed world; the order we see might arise from principles internal to matter rather than from an external mind; and the existence of evil and suffering poses the ancient problem that Philo restates in its sharpest form – the old questions of Epicurus, whether the deity is willing to prevent evil but unable, or able but unwilling, or neither, or both. Hume’s settled view, so far as the carefully balanced *Dialogues* permit one to be inferred, is a thoroughgoing religious skepticism that leaves natural theology in ruins while stopping

short of dogmatic atheism – an agnosticism of temper as much as of doctrine, consistent with the mitigated skepticism that governs the whole of his thought.

10 The Reception and Afterlife of Hume

Hume’s influence on subsequent philosophy is surpassed by no one in the modern period, and it runs through every area he touched.

The most famous single effect was on Kant, who reported that it was the recollection of Hume – specifically Hume on causation – that interrupted his “dogmatic slumber” and gave his critical philosophy its direction. The whole apparatus of the *Critique of Pure Reason*, with its synthetic *a priori* and its categories of the understanding (causation among them) supplied by the mind to constitute experience, is an attempt to answer Hume’s challenge: to show how necessary causal knowledge is possible after all, by locating its source in the structure of cognition rather than in the objects. Whether Kant succeeded in escaping the Humean predicament or merely relocated it has been argued ever since, but the agenda was set by Hume.

In the theory of knowledge, Hume’s Fork strongly shaped the logical positivists of the twentieth century, who transformed the division between relations of ideas and matters of fact into the analytic/synthetic distinction and built upon it a verificationist, anti-metaphysical programme, on which only the analytic and the empirically verifiable count as meaningful. In A. J. Ayer’s hands the result reads like the closing pages of the first *Enquiry* rewritten in modern dress. Hume’s problem of induction became, and remains, a central and unsolved problem of philosophy of science: Popper’s falsificationism, the various reliabilist and pragmatic responses, Bayesian confirmation theory, and Nelson Goodman’s “new riddle” of projectibility (the grue problem) are all attempts to live with exactly the gap Hume opened, and the same lineage runs through the late Russell, who conceded that strict empiricism could not justify scientific inference without unprovable postulates.

On causation, the contemporary debate divides along Humean lines. Regularity theories, counterfactual analyses such as David Lewis’s, and the elaborate machinery of J. L. Mackie all begin from broadly Humean reductions of causation to patterns among events rather than hidden powers; while the *New Hume* controversy – between projectivist readings descending from Simon Blackburn and the skeptical-realist reading argued by Galen Strawson and others – keeps alive the question of what Hume himself believed about real powers in nature. In ethics, Hume is the acknowledged founder of two enduring traditions: the *sentimentalist* account of moral judgement, revived in recent decades, and the *non-cognitivist* or *expressivist* analysis of moral language, from Ayer’s emotivism through

Blackburn's quasi-realism and Allan Gibbard's work, all of which descend from the thesis that moral judgements express sentiment rather than describe fact. The is-ought gap remains a fixed point of meta-ethical debate, with attempts to bridge it – John Searle's derivation of "ought" from "is" by way of the institution of promising being the best known – still measured against Hume's challenge. And Hume's compatibilism remains one of the standard positions in the free-will debate, while his treatment of justice as a useful convention prefigures modern theories of convention and spontaneous order.

The interpretation of Hume himself has shifted accordingly. An older tradition read him as primarily a destructive skeptic; the influential naturalist reading associated with Norman Kemp Smith, and developed by later scholars such as Barry Stroud and Don Garrett, recovered the constructive side – the Hume for whom custom, sentiment, and natural belief are not merely what is left after reason fails but the proper foundation of a positive science of human nature. The balance between the skeptic and the naturalist is, like the New Hume debate and the reading of the *Dialogues*, still genuinely open, which is itself a measure of the depth of the texts.

11 Modern Criticism of Hume

So commanding is Hume's influence that a great deal of modern philosophy is organised around accepting or resisting his theses, and the labels "Humean" and "anti-Humean" now mark standard dividing lines in metaphysics, the theory of motivation, and the philosophy of science. The criticisms accordingly track the central questions, and several remain live disputes rather than settled refutations.

11.1 The narrowness of Humean reason

A recurring objection, applying with special force to the problem of induction, is that Hume's skeptical results depend on a deliberately narrow conception of reason. He confines rational justification to two channels – demonstrative reasoning from relations of ideas, and probable reasoning from experience – and then shows that neither can underwrite the inference from observed to unobserved. But critics question whether that dichotomy is exhaustive. If there are further legitimate forms of inference, such as inference to the best explanation, or a non-inferential entitlement to take experience at face value, then the demand that induction be justified either demonstratively or by a non-circular appeal to experience may be the wrong demand. The most influential dissolution of the problem, due to P. F. Strawson, argues that to call a belief reasonable just is, in part, to say that it is well supported by inductive evidence, so that to ask for an external justification of induction as a whole is to ask whether the standard of reasonableness is itself reasonable – a confused question. Whether this dissolves the problem or merely

renames it is disputed, and Nelson Goodman's "new riddle" – the grue problem, which shows that the notion of which regularities are projectible needs an account Hume never gave – suggests the difficulty is deeper than Hume saw rather than easier. The common thread of these responses is that the Humean problem may rest on a contestable picture of what rational justification must be.

11.2 The theory of ideas and the Copy Principle

Hume's foundational apparatus – the imagist theory of ideas and the Copy Principle that governs it – is among the parts of his system least defended today. Three lines of objection converge. First, the Copy Principle, as a thesis of concept-empiricism, faces a wide range of apparent counterexamples beyond the missing shade of blue that Hume himself conceded: the concepts of logic and mathematics, of negation and identity, of causation and the self, do not look like faded copies of any sensory impression, and Kant's response – that some concepts are a priori forms the mind brings to experience rather than abstractions from it – set the agenda for the rejection of strict empiricism about concepts. Second, the imagist model of an idea as a faint replica of an impression has been abandoned in modern philosophy of mind and language, which denies that concepts are mental images at all. Third, the atomistic, foundational starting point – the attempt to build knowledge up from individual, self-standing impressions – runs against the holism of meaning associated with Quine, whose attack on the sharp analytic/synthetic distinction undermined one prong of Hume's Fork, and against Wilfrid Sellars's critique of the "Myth of the Given," which denies that there is any layer of bare sensory data able to serve as the self-certifying foundation Hume's impressions were meant to provide. The empiricist principle survives as a salutary demand for the experiential cash-value of our concepts; the particular psychology in which Hume cast it does not.

11.3 Causation and the laws of nature

Hume's analysis of causation is the source of a vast modern literature largely devoted to escaping it. Internal difficulties were noticed early: his two definitions of cause are not equivalent, the first appealing to a global regularity and the second to the transition in a particular mind, so that the same pair of events might satisfy one and not the other. The regularity account faces the standard battery of counterexamples – accidental regularities that are not causal, the asymmetry between cause and effect that mere constant conjunction cannot capture, and singular causation in cases instantiating no evident regularity. Much of contemporary metaphysics is, in effect, a revolt against the Humean picture: David Armstrong's account of laws as relations of necessitation between universals, the dispositional-essentialist and causal-powers theories of writers such as Nancy Cartwright, and the counterfactual analyses descending from David Lewis all arose because the bare

regularity view seemed unable to capture the modal force and the directionality of causation. “Humean supervenience” – the thesis that all there is to the world is the distribution of local, non-modal matters of fact, with laws and causes supervening on that mosaic – is now a named position precisely so that it can be attacked. Whether Hume himself held the austere reductionism here under fire is, as noted above, the subject of the *New Hume* debate; but the reductionist view that bears his name remains the principal target in the field.

11.4 The self

The bundle theory drew Hume’s own confession of failure, and the objection that prompted it has been pressed ever since: a bundle requires something to bundle it, and the account seems unable to explain the unity of consciousness, or the sense in which a set of perceptions is *one* mind’s perceptions, without reintroducing the very subject it set out to eliminate. Kant’s doctrine of the transcendental unity of apperception – that a single “I think” must be able to accompany all my representations if they are to be experiences at all – is the classic response, locating a necessary unity that Hume’s inventory of perceptions cannot supply. Yet the no-self view has not so much been refuted as developed: Derek Parfit’s reductionism about personal identity, on which identity consists in relations of psychological continuity and connectedness among experiences rather than in a further fact about a persisting ego, is a direct and influential descendant of Hume’s bundle, and shows that the position retains serious defenders.

11.5 Moral philosophy: motivation, the is–ought gap, and normativity

Hume’s ethics is contested at each of its load-bearing points. The *Humean theory of motivation* – that belief alone cannot move us and that every action requires an independent desire, itself not subject to rational assessment – is rejected by moral rationalists who hold that reason can be practical: Thomas Nagel and Christine Korsgaard, in different ways, argue that rational reflection can itself generate motivation, and the dispute between such views and the broadly Humean “internal reasons” defended by Bernard Williams is among the central debates of contemporary meta-ethics. The *is–ought gap* has likewise been challenged. John Searle’s attempted derivation of “ought” from “is” by way of the institution of promising is the best-known frontal assault; the theorists of “thick” ethical concepts – Williams, Philippa Foot, and Elizabeth Anscombe among them – argue that concepts such as *cruel* or *courageous* fuse description and evaluation in a way the clean fact/value separation cannot accommodate; and Alasdair MacIntyre has argued that the supposed gap is an artefact of a particular and impoverished modern

conception of morality rather than a timeless logical truth. The sentimentalist foundation, finally, faces the same normativity worry that attends Smith: an account of which sentiments we feel, however refined by the general point of view, seems to leave open the further question of which sentiments we *ought* to feel, so that the passage from approval to genuine obligation is not obviously secured. None of these objections is decisive, but together they show that Hume's moral philosophy is not a closed achievement but a standing provocation.

11.6 Religion: the argument against miracles

The most pointed modern criticism in the philosophy of religion targets the argument of "Of Miracles." John Earman, in a study pointedly titled *Hume's Abject Failure* (2000), argues that when Hume's reasoning is reconstructed as the piece of probabilistic inference it purports to be, it is either invalid or trivial: it establishes at most the unsurprising point that extraordinary claims require strong evidence, not the stronger conclusion Hume seems to want, and a proper Bayesian treatment shows that sufficiently strong and independent testimony could in principle outweigh even a very low prior. A further objection charges the argument with begging the question, since defining a law of nature as a uniformity to which experience admits no exception comes close to ruling out miracles by stipulation. Defenders reply that a charitable reconstruction preserves a genuine and important insight about weighing testimony against background regularity. By contrast Hume's critique of the design argument in the *Dialogues* has worn better – though even there the modern fine-tuning arguments have revived design-style reasoning that Hume's objections must now be brought to bear upon afresh.

11.7 What survives

As with the parallel reckonings over Smith and Hegel, the criticisms fall most heavily on Hume's specific doctrines – the imagist Copy Principle, the regularity reduction of causation, arguably the bundle theory – while leaving his framing power and his method largely intact, indeed strengthened. The questions Hume posed remain the reference points of their fields: no treatment of induction, causation, the self, the fact/value distinction, or miracles can avoid beginning from him, and the very theories that reject his answers define themselves, by the labels they accept or refuse, in relation to his. His naturalistic ambition – to study the mind as a part of nature, by observation rather than by a priori legislation – has become the working assumption of the cognitive sciences that now pursue his "science of man" with instruments he could not have imagined. What modern philosophy has discarded are Hume's eighteenth-century mechanisms; what it has kept is his agenda and his temper. The arguments are contested at every turn, and that they are still the arguments one must contest is the surest measure of their depth.

12 Conclusion: The Shape of Hume's Thought

The unity of Hume's philosophy is the unity of a single, fearless application of the empiricist principle across the whole field of human concern. Trace every idea to its impression; accept only what experience can warrant; and follow the argument wherever it leads, even when it leads to the conclusion that our most basic convictions – that causes necessitate their effects, that the future will resemble the past, that we are continuing selves in a world of enduring bodies, that some characters are really virtuous and others really vicious – cannot be founded on reason at all. What makes Hume more than a skeptic is the second half of the pattern: the recognition that these convictions, though rationally ungrounded, are not therefore abandoned, because they are rooted in something deeper than reason. Custom carries us from the observed to the unobserved; natural propensities of the imagination give us the self and the external world; sentiment, extended by sympathy and steadied by a common point of view, gives us morality. Reason is dethroned, but nature reigns in its place, and human life goes on, now understood for what it is.

This is the achievement that places Hume at the head of the empiricist tradition and makes him the indispensable interlocutor of nearly everything that followed: the philosopher who set the problem of causation for Kant, the problem of induction for the philosophy of science, the is-ought gap for ethics, and the very idea of a naturalistic science of the mind for the disciplines that now pursue it. His temper – skeptical without despair, naturalist without dogmatism, and unfailingly humane – is as much a part of his legacy as his arguments. He showed how little reason can prove and how much nature makes us believe, and he taught philosophy to be modest about the first while honest about the second.

13 Suggested Primary Reading

The natural points of entry, in ascending order of difficulty, are the two *Enquiries*. The *Enquiry concerning Human Understanding* (1748) is the best first text: its sections on the origin of ideas, the association of ideas, sceptical doubts and the sceptical solution (the heart of the treatment of causation and induction), the idea of necessary connexion, liberty and necessity, and miracles contain the core of Hume's theoretical philosophy in compact form. The *Enquiry concerning the Principles of Morals* (1751), which Hume thought his best work, gives the mature moral philosophy, with its account of utility, sympathy, the general point of view, and the artificial virtue of justice. *A Treatise of Human Nature* (1739–1740) is the fuller and more demanding original, indispensable for the bundle theory of the self (Book I, Part IV), the theory of the passions (Book II), and the foundations of morals including the is-ought passage and the artificiality of justice (Book III). The *Dialogues concerning Natural Religion* (1779) is the essential text on

the philosophy of religion and is, in addition, a model of philosophical dialogue. Among secondary works, Norman Kemp Smith's study established the naturalist reading, and Barry Stroud's *Hume* (1977) remains a clear and reliable guide to the whole.